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How to prepare for your house design

A guide for clients · 6 steps before your first meeting with an architect

Before you start

A good house design begins long before the first line is drawn. Clients who come to the first meeting with complete information about their plot, budget and needs get a better design – faster and for less.

This guide collects the questions we hear most often at the studio. Go through it with your family: it takes one evening and saves weeks of revisions.

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01

The plot

Before you buy a plot or start a design, check what you are allowed to build on it.

The local zoning plan sets out, among other things, building height, roof pitch, building lines and minimum green area.

No zoning plan? You will need a planning decision, and whether it can be issued depends on the municipal general plan.

Road access and utilities – ask about connections: electricity, water, sewage, gas. No sewer means a septic tank or treatment plant.

Soil – a geotechnical survey shows whether more expensive foundations will be needed.

Sun and views – visit the plot in the morning and evening. Orientation affects the layout and your energy bills.

02

Documents

Documents worth having before the meeting:

- zoning plan extract or planning decision,
- a survey map for design purposes (ordered from a land surveyor, about 3–6 weeks),
- geotechnical documentation (soil investigation),
- utility connection conditions from network operators,
- title deed or land register extract,
- photos of the plot and surroundings if we work remotely.

Missing something? No problem – we can help you order some documents during the design.

03

How we live

The most important exercise in this guide. Answer the questions together:

- How many people will live in the house now, and in 10 years?
- Who works from home and needs a quiet study?
- How often do you have guests, and how many at once?
- Do you need a ground-floor bedroom (e.g. for parents)?
- How many cars and bikes need storage?
- Which hobbies need space: a workshop, gym or studio?

Also write down three things you like about your current home and three that annoy you. It is the best brief an architect can get.

04

Budget

Set a budget for the whole investment, not just construction. An indicative split:

- design and permits: 3–5%,
- closed shell: 35–40%,
- building services (incl. heat pump, MVHR): 15–20%,
- interior fit-out: 25–30%,
- landscaping: 5–8%,
- **contingency: 10–15%** – for the surprises every building site brings.

Tell your architect about the budget straight away, so the design is buildable from day one.

05

Timeline

A typical path from idea to building permit:

- consultation and proposal: 1–2 weeks,
- survey map for design purposes: 3–6 weeks (in parallel),
- concept with visualisations: 4–6 weeks,
- building design: 6–10 weeks,
- building permit decision: up to 65 days by law,
- technical design: 4–8 weeks (can run while you wait for the permit).

Usually 6–9 months in total. If you want to start building in spring, start the design in the autumn before.

06

Questions for your architect

Ask them at the first meeting – with any studio:

- What exactly does the price include, and how many rounds of revisions?
- Who will lead my project and how quickly do they answer questions?
- Can I see completed houses, not just visualisations?
- Who coordinates the structure and building services?
- Is design supervision included – and if not, what does it cost?
- How does the contract deal with copyright and deadlines?

At LINEA you will find the answers in our proposal – before you sign anything.

Let's talk

The first 45-minute consultation is free. Book it via the form on our website, by phone at +48 42 123 45 67 or by e-mail: biuro@linea-architekci.pl.

LINEA is a fictional company – a student project (Internet Marketing, Lodz University of Technology, 2026). The information is general and does not constitute legal advice.